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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Sexual Health, Consent and Relationships: Decide With Information

Factual, judgement-free guidance on consent, protection and getting care

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Freshers receive a lot of rumour and very little accurate information. This pack covers consent, contraception and barrier protection, common sexually transmitted infections, testing and where to get confidential care, with no moralising and no shame.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Define consent and describe the conditions that make it valid.
- Compare contraceptive methods and explain barrier protection.
- Recognise common STI symptoms and know that many infections are asymptomatic.
- Identify confidential sources of testing, treatment and support.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Consent and boundaries

Consent is an ongoing agreement, not a single moment.

- Consent must be freely given, informed, specific and reversible.
- A person can withdraw consent at any time, including during an act.
- Silence, coercion, pressure or intoxication do not constitute consent.
- Marriage or a previous relationship does not remove the need for consent.
- Agreeing to one act does not imply agreement to another.
- Respect a no immediately, and stop if you are unsure.

Support after assault
Seek medical attention quickly, preserve evidence where possible, and contact a trusted person or support service. What happened is not the survivor's fault.

Protection and contraception

Different methods do different jobs: contraception prevents pregnancy, while barrier protection reduces infection risk.

- Male condoms reduce the risk of pregnancy and most STIs when used correctly and consistently.
- Hormonal methods such as pills and injectables prevent pregnancy but do not protect against infection.
- Long-acting reversible methods are highly effective and require a provider.
- Emergency contraception reduces pregnancy risk after unprotected sex but is not routine contraception.
- Two methods used together give better protection than one alone.
- Consult a health provider before starting any method.

Infections, testing and care

Many STIs have no symptoms, so testing matters more than appearance.

- Common infections include HIV, gonorrhoea, chlamydia, syphilis, herpes and HPV.
- Symptoms can include discharge, sores, pain or burning on urination, but absence of symptoms is common.
- Testing is confidential and available at the university health centre and public facilities.
- Most bacterial STIs are curable with the right treatment; viral infections can be managed.
- Complete a full course of treatment and inform partners where appropriate.
- Never self-medicate with antibiotics from a chemist without testing.

Consent is a standard, not a mood

Consent is a clear, voluntary and informed agreement to a specific activity, given by someone with the capacity to give it. It can be withdrawn at any point, and it cannot be given in advance for an activity that has not been discussed. Silence is not consent; previous consent does not extend to a new occasion; being in a relationship does not create standing consent.

Alcohol and drugs complicate capacity. A person who is significantly intoxicated may not be able to give valid consent, and sex without valid consent is rape or sexual assault regardless of the relationship or the intentions of the other person.

Coercion includes pressure, guilt, threats, emotional manipulation and refusing to accept a no. Repeatedly asking until someone gives in is not persuasion; it is coercion. A healthy sexual relationship is one in which either person can say no without consequence.

Protection, testing and reproductive health